Marking your turning

A blunted, soft lead pencil along with your indexing head will help with marking out pattern spacing

A good artist's eraser can remove layout lines provided you haven't indented the wood fibres

You can work in a totally random manner if you wish. On occasion, it can be a very attractive solution. More often, a carved or pyrographed pattern in a selected area offers interest and imparts that 'handcrafted' feeling. While you'll try to make things fit the pattern, the minor variations that are almost impossible to avoid lend to the 'done by hand' impression. Laying out your pattern or design ahead of time is a good idea. Pencilling in your plan will let you see how best it will work and lets you make mistakes that are reversible. I use the indexing head on my lathe and a pencil laying on the toolrest to mark out my plans. Until I'm content with the plan, an eraser is all that is needed to get back to ground zero.

Most of us don't have the capability to create artistic patterns freehand. If you do, good for you, but I find I need to layout or trace my plans onto the turning. If it is a simple fluting or rotationally laid out pattern, I use the indexing head on my lathe as an aid. Locking the turning at the various angles of rotation, I can mark the turning using the toolrest. *Woodturning* 267, June 2014, has a wealth of information on using the lathe as a marking aid along with methods of layout if your lathe isn't equipped with an indexing head. Even with a regular pattern, you have the opportunity to vary it slightly to make it less perfect. You can also use flexible protractors, compasses and printed patterns to aid with your pattern creation and application to the work. My preferred marking device is a dull, soft pencil. I want to place markings that can be seen but don't make any indentations on the wood. That allows for erasure of the marks should I change my mind, not use all of the marks, or remove marks when done. A soft artist's pencil works great. You can sharpen it to a point and then round it on a bit of sandpaper. If you wish to draw or trace a pattern or design on the wood, Saral paper, used by artists, works extremely well. It is a graphite paper that will leave a visible design yet can be removed if needed. Should you wish to use a more exotic pattern and have a photocopy or computer printed version, attach it to the surface using rubber cement. You'll need to relieve the paper pattern with slits to allow for attachment to a curved surface. You can cut or burn right through this attached pattern. An alternative idea is to attach the pattern to some Saral paper and then trace the pattern allowing the paper to impart the graphite to the surface.

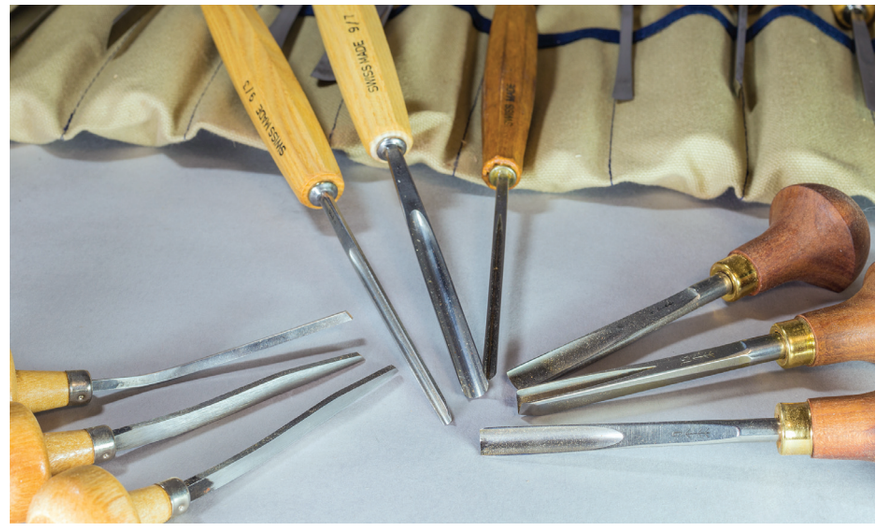
Key points

- Use a dull point, whether pencil or rubbing device, to mark the wood.
- Do not use carbon paper! It is difficult to remove should you change.
- Use artist's Saral paper for tracing patterns. It is expensive but reusable.
- The internet is a huge source of designs and design ideas.
- Scaling of designs/patterns can be done via the computer or photocopier.
- Keep the wood clean by wearing clean gloves if necessary.

Carving accent patterns

When I'm happy with the plan, I use the lathe as my workholder and begin my carving. A suggestion that I'll offer is to do the carving in stages. Rather than commit to any regular pattern density, I begin by skipping the marks in an organised manner to see the effect before getting too dense. I can go back and execute the skipped marks if it seems to work better. I also make my carved depths very shallow to begin with. I can always return to make them deeper when needed. If you begin with things being carved too deeply, you have no way to regroup.

Your selection of carving tools can range from the inexpensive palm carving tools to the very high end carving tools. Properly sharpened and presented, they will all get the job done. In addition to hand tools, there are power carvers



If properly sharpened, carving tools from the most modest to the highest end will work

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